

# **Danish Philosophers**

Harald Høffding

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# Introduction

A small country such as ours lies open to influences from without. The spiritual currents from the great centres of culture reach decisively into its intellectual life, and this life cannot attain that firm continuity through the ages which becomes possible when a country is able to bring forth a great multiplicity of thinking minds — minds that never let development come to a standstill and that, through the various types they present, can break the influences coming from abroad, so that the continuity in a people's intellectual life may be the better preserved.

Nevertheless, serious and independent thought has been devoted here at home to the questions that it is philosophy's calling to discuss — the presuppositions of science, the significance of its results for one's view of life, the foundation of ethical evaluation, the nature and laws of the human spirit, the relation between religion and humanity. The influences from without have been assimilated in a distinctive way, and our national character has shown itself in the manner in which the problems have been treated. In the treatment of such questions as those mentioned, which lie on the borders between strict science and life, the personalities of the thinkers must necessarily contribute in a higher degree than in other inquiries. And where personality operates according to its whole distinctiveness, the national traits too assert themselves. For these are not layers or pieces joined from without to the other qualities of individuals, but determine those qualities from the very first and sound along with them, every time the strings of the mind are struck.

That Danish thought has its own distinctive character can be seen by comparison with Swedish thought. Sweden's intellectual life has received the same currents from abroad as Denmark's, but in the domain of thought these have been assimilated and developed in another way and in another direction than with us. Speculation and mysticism have played a far greater role in Sweden than in Denmark, and, bound up with this, an urge toward systematic completeness has asserted itself there which has never found firm ground with us. Danish thought has been essentially borne by a psychological and ethical interest, and again and again a level-headed criticism has made itself felt against

the construction of systems.<sup>1</sup> Among our foremost thinking minds (Holberg, the Ørsteds, Sibbern, Kierkegaard) this distinctive character makes itself felt, and it gives rise to thoughts and works which, though they have not entered into the great international discussion of the questions of knowledge and of life, nonetheless have their value — and that not for us alone. A characterization of the Danish philosophers can teach us a great deal by way of orientation toward those questions, and it will often appear that our thinkers might very well have made their mark on a larger stage, had circumstances assigned them one. The heaven of thought is, like the physical heaven, accessible to all, not only to those born among a great people. This book will therefore be able to cast light on the philosophical problems themselves, and not merely serve to characterize Danish intellectual life as it expresses itself in the domain of thought.

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<sup>1</sup>See my essay on Swedish and Danish philosophy in the collection *Norden* (1902), as well as my essay *Filosofien i Sverige* [Philosophy in Sweden] (*Det Letterstedtske Tidsskrift*, 1879). — On the philosophical movements abroad that come to influence Danish philosophy, fuller information will be found in my work *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* [The History of Modern Philosophy] by means of the index. — Biographies I do not as a rule give, chiefly because I can refer to the excellent articles by my colleague Professor Kroman in the *Biografisk Leksikon*.

# I. Ludvig Holberg

Danish philosophy begins with the very founder of our literature. He is the first here at home to take an independent stand on the problems of thought, at the same time as he brings the ideas and attempted solutions that had arisen abroad into Danish intellectual life.

Holberg no doubt stands first and foremost for us as a poet, but it would be wrong to see him solely from this point of view and to interpret his moods amid the vicissitudes of his life merely in the light of the fate his poetic work met with. Inquiry held a central interest for him and filled an essential part of his life, from his young days to his advanced old age. He held, as does his Erasmus Montanus, that studies are an ornament in the days of good fortune and a consolation in those of misfortune. Nothing befell him so heavily that it was not made lighter by study — as he himself said. It is characteristic that a similar remark is attributed to Leibniz, who likewise had a many-sided interest in reading and inquiry. But Leibniz had a brighter and lighter view of life and of men than Holberg, whose heavy nature did not let him rest content with the crystal-clear prism into which Leibniz had ground his view of life. He could not be led by speculative considerations to overlook the disharmonies of life or to be reconciled with them. For Holberg the evil in the world was a hardship not so easily broken. Human life suffered in particular under a great opposition between appearance and reality. “The shadow is taken for the body” — this expression recurs again and again in Holberg, and he wrote his comedies, his *Niels Klim*, and his *Moralske Tanker* [Moral Reflections] in order to counteract this perpetual confusion. He does not wish to preach morality, but to tear illusions apart and awaken men to self-knowledge.

When he thus ascribes to himself an express moral purpose in all his works, this is to be understood only as an interpretation he afterwards placed upon his authorship. There was of course at work in him an involuntary urge to unfold his intellectual power in the fields of poetry, historical research, and thought, and only when in his old age he looked back on his rich and manifold activity did he find, in a moral aim, a somewhat artificial

and philistine explanation.<sup>2</sup> But his work of thought was a side of his activity that he looked back upon with particular pleasure. Just as he thought he could “say without scruple that he is almost the first Dane who, in place of meagre and confused chronicles, has given us tolerably well-ordered histories,” so too he prided himself on having “set the study of morals on its feet again, which right up to this time had lain as if buried here in the North.”

But Holberg was not merely a moral philosopher. He occupied himself with the new science and the new view of the world that had developed in the age of the Renaissance, and whose most conspicuous and at the same time most far-reaching results were the changed position of the Earth in the picture of the world and the unboundedness of the world. And besides this, his thought was taken up with the great oppositions of the world and of life, which culminated in the problem of evil — a problem that in Holberg’s very youth was being discussed by such great thinkers as Bayle and Leibniz.

His thought loved to set oppositions sharply against one another, so that the problem might spring forth all the more from the strong collision — the opposition, for example, between the infinite horizon that science had opened up and human life with its striving and its wishes; the oppositions within human nature; the conflict of good and evil. In treating questions of this kind he was fond of “paradoxical opinions,” by which he understood such as “with good reasons overturn the opinions that have gained citizenship.” It was not a bent for hair-splitting or for playing with ideas that guided him here: the paradoxes had to have “probability” — that is, to be really well-founded — and this they were when it was widened experience that led to them. He saw that when one places oneself on the broad ground of experience — when one bases one’s judgments on experience — one comes to doubt much that had hitherto stood as self-evident. It is no wonder that one arrives at fixed opinions when one holds to the given traditions and lets them determine what one experiences and how one interprets what one has experienced.

It is on this point above all that Holberg’s significance as a thinker lies — in the weight he places on as wide an experience as possible and on the problems that experience presents at any given time. Both these tendencies make a conclusive systematization difficult, if not impossible. When Holberg, in the preface to *Moralske Tanker*, speaks of completing his system,<sup>3</sup> he surely meant thereby only a rounding-off or conclusion so far as his own person was concerned. Even the most open and acute thinker halts at

<sup>2</sup>Compare my essay on Holberg in *Mindre Arbejder* [Minor Works], Second Series, pp. 150–153.

<sup>3</sup>“In view of my age and infirmity, I regard myself as a man ready to set out on a journey, who must draw up his *Systema* before he takes his leave and sets off.”



a boundary, but he need not regard this boundary as the boundary of all thought and experience.

With this it agrees that when Holberg is to say to which philosophers he owes the most, he names John Locke, the chief representative of empiricist philosophy, and Pierre Bayle, the great critic and raiser of problems. On the whole he owes most to English and French intellectual life. Nowhere on his travels abroad did he feel so much at home as in Oxford and Paris. He rejoiced that he had come to study at the French and English academies, and he called England in particular “the true school of philosophy.”

When Holberg, after his travels, after the experience he had gathered, and after his thought had been sharpened by his persistent occupation with the problems of the age, attempted to philosophize in the Danish academic world, great difficulties arose for him from various quarters.

The Danish language was but little fashioned for more advanced thinking; it had narrow limits to its diffusion — and within those limits it was not respected by its own people. “My name,” says Holberg, “might perhaps have been tolerably well known abroad, had I not written in the Danish language, which is so confined that often in Denmark itself one must search for someone who understands it.” The greater gratitude must we feel toward the founder of our literature that he did not despise this language, but did what he could to cultivate it into an instrument for thought. Had he, for the sake of his fame, written in a foreign tongue, a Danish life of thought would not have developed. What he began was carried on by his successors, especially by Eilschow, Sneedorff, and Kraft.

But in this still little-developed language one could not express oneself so freely as in the other countries, especially in England. “Here in our North,” says Holberg, “we are plagued with sharp censorships, by which all gaiety and spirit are damped in a writer.” When a book is furnished with an “Imprimatur,” it is usually a sign that there is nothing to it. It was above all from the theological side that the censorship was prompted; Holberg noticed this especially with *Niels Klim*. “I took particular care that the clergy should not get occasion to array themselves in armour against me, since I know from experience that these people are the most implacable.” “It is only those adversaries I fear who clothe themselves in the armour of religion.” And in his last years he grew even more cautious: “I put my words and writings on screws more than before, since I have noticed that at one time they were being examined more closely.” — Holberg’s religious opinions were not orthodox. Of that there is no doubt, though it may be difficult to decide where earnestness leaves off in his utterances and where caution begins. People have exaggerated both the

earnestness and the caution — have found both more orthodoxy and more tactics in him than there are. He had his theology, which he held to be reasonable and consonant with his experience. It goes not much further than Rousseau's and Kant's, but he thought that, by right interpretation, it could be said to be contained in the biblical and dogmatic conceptions.

Most of the students (two-thirds) at the University of Copenhagen in Holberg's time studied theology, and the scholastic philosophy still cultivated here at home was regarded as an important means of guarding the true doctrine. By formal logic thought was to be trained in distinctions and syllogisms so as to be able to set dogmatics in system. In *Erasmus Montanus* Holberg presents a young dialectical fencer of the kind that the constant disputation exercises were bound to produce. His formal virtuosity drives him to undertake to prove whatsoever it may be. "That is why," says Erasmus Montanus, "I have studied, and that is why I have racked my brains, so that I can say what I will and defend it before the whole world." In the scenes where Erasmus disputes with the folk on the Hill, however, Holberg does not let him use the logic that was taught at the university. Erasmus is fond of proceeding by affirmative syllogisms in the second figure,<sup>4</sup> which scholasticism knew very well to be invalid. But Holberg employs such sophisms as Aristophanes and Plato had already ascribed to their opponents. Instead of showing the uselessness of formal quibbling, he has achieved a comic effect through the way in which the respect that the folk on the Hill nonetheless had for Copenhagen learning caused sheer nonsense to stand as proven truth.

Among the subjects to which logical acuteness is applied, Erasmus names first and foremost the theological ones — for example, the question whether the angels were created before men. But such questions are named too as whether the Earth is round or oval, and concerning the distance and size of the sun and stars; and it is on a question of this latter kind that Erasmus is brought down by the home-grown Inquisition. Now it is characteristic that questions of this latter kind interested Holberg himself in a high degree and led him to some of his boldest thoughts, as will be shown in what follows. Here he had "the Hill" and "the learned men of the Hill" against himself, and he would have come into a conflict similar to that of Erasmus Montanus, had he here openly drawn the consequences. But in the comedy his main concern was to set useful studies over against mere sword-play, and so he was ruthless enough to let Erasmus fall precisely where he was in the right. The Lieutenant in the fifth act, the play's moralist, has, like Holberg, chiefly studied "Latin authors, natural law, and moral matters," which Montanus

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<sup>4</sup>A is B and C is B, therefore A is C! Nille cannot fly, a stone cannot fly, therefore Nille is a stone!

regards as trifling. The moral of the play is expressed in the Lieutenant's words: "The first commandment in philosophy is to know oneself. . . The more one does, the more there seems to remain to learn. But you make philosophy into an art of fencing."

Instead of the subtleties or the broodings over the nature of God and the angels that were then called metaphysics, Holberg wished to turn to subjects that could yield a positive return for philosophizing. Instead of countless uncertain things he wanted a few certain ones. — Let us then bring forward the chief questions that especially occupied Holberg's thought.

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Often in his later years Holberg declares that moral philosophy is his real study. The chief work here is *Moralske Tanker* (1744). It is not a systematic book, but a series of little essays that occasionally stray into less scientific subjects, for there is talk not only of poetry and of studies, but also of the reasons why the author has not married, and of the interesting question whether a bad stomach is as bad as a bad wife. But the main thought, to which he returns again and again, is that there exists a morality founded on the light of nature. In his *Epistler* [Epistles] too, the other chief source of his philosophy, he maintains this proposition. "Natural morals are one study, theological morals another. When one undertakes to write of the former, it is required that one found the doctrine on the light of nature." But natural morality is not, as was claimed, "a heathen morality." "Christ's morality" too is founded on the light of nature; the difference is merely that the same "morality" is carried out in greater perfection.

Holberg's ethics is religious in so far as he connects it with "natural religion." But he will have morality placed before the special dogmas and mysteries. "One must, through Christ's morality and a sound philosophy, lay the foundation before the dogmas and mysteries of Christianity are taught." "Children must be made into human beings before they become Christians." A human confirmation must precede the Christian one; for if a person learns theology before he learns to become a human being, he never becomes a human being. "One begins by crying: Believe! before one shows what one ought to believe and not to believe. That is to go to work like that judge who began with the execution and afterwards had the case examined." One ought to impart to men a critical faculty, that they may not take the shadow for the body.

For Holberg the foundation of the Reformation was "the Christian freedom to search before one believes." "It is in a person's power to search, but not to believe." Error after careful examination is more excusable than orthodoxy without preceding inquiry. Strife is better than brutal concord. Holberg himself would rather read heretics than

the orthodox, because the latter answer more with abuse than with reasons. And it was his conviction that one had to give up the outworks of the doctrine of faith in order to defend the main fortress the better. For his own part he was willing to subscribe to all the fundamental articles of faith found in the Confession; yet he would rather reduce than increase their number, for there is need of nowhere near so many articles of faith as are commonly alleged to be quite necessary. — Unfortunately Holberg does not say which ones he would strike out.

He will not have inquiry brought to a halt by one's taking refuge in "God's motives and reserved causes" or "the imperfection of reason and God's inscrutable ways." That is a sign of laziness. Such an appeal is permissible only when one has striven with all one's might to find out the cause and has sought to reconcile the difficulties that arise with reason.

Nevertheless, as already indicated, there is in Holberg's moral catechism (*Epistle 46*) both a religious and a rational element. It is founded on natural religion. The first three articles treat of God and immortality. The fourth article demands that no doctrine be accepted before it is made demonstrable; for otherwise one may fall into false belief as readily as into true, and reason, God's most excellent gift, would be of no use. The fifth article demands the rejection of all doctrines that conflict with God's holy attributes, and the sixth runs thus: Hate and persecute no one who against his will goes astray in his faith!

Of the two elements the rational lies deepest, and logically the fourth article ought to have been placed before the three preceding ones. Very clear is a statement from *Moralske Tanker* that the right method would be to explain to the young the chief commandments of nature, to set forth what fairness, justice, and goodness are — that they are virtues in God's creatures and *therefore* must consistently be attributes of the Godhead itself. — Thus the attributes ascribed to God must first be known from the human world. It is then a circular inference when one derives morality from theology, grounding human justice by the divine. The ethical, according to Holberg, takes priority over the religious; the latter is understood by means of the former, before the reverse can become the case.

The "light of nature" Holberg finds revealed in certain principles that for him are immediately evident. "The great commandment of nature": Do not to others what you would not have them do to you! — will, he thinks, be granted by everyone who hears it explained — even though Locke is right that it cannot be said to be innate. It is as clear as that a thing cannot at one and the same time be and not be. — Morality thus has its own source, even though it stands in close connection with natural religion. Whether that

principle is really self-evident is another question. The problem of how we come to set up the principles on which all ethical demonstration rests, Holberg does not enter into.

As regards the individual qualities and actions, Holberg impresses upon us that all perfection depends on a definite limitation: "All virtue consists in mediocrity, and as soon as it passes beyond the bounds, it is metamorphosed into vice." "The Danish proverb, Fear God and follow the highway! is quite well founded; for those who are always looking for byways and wish to shorten the roads most often arrive last. And it is of such crafty wayfarers that people here in this country say that they go by Per Gante's shortcut." — Unfortunately there is perhaps something Danish in these rules. But one would gravely misunderstand Holberg if one supposed that he recommends a middle-of-the-road morality. He does so as little as Aristotle did in his doctrine of virtue as the right mean.<sup>5</sup> What is too much or too little is determined by the individual's nature and may differ from individual to individual. What for one is a byway may be a highway for another. It was not Holberg's meaning to exclude new roads. His comparisons and examples show clearly what he means. In case of sickness one patient is to have one pill, another two or three. A choleric man must be judged otherwise than one born with a "temperate complexion." One who has no gall cannot be praised for coolness of temper. To ride on a tame ass is no merit, but to govern a wild and mettlesome horse deserves applause and clapping of hands. In the chastisement of misdeeds the punishment ought to be fitted to the malefactor's constitution; a misdeed may be equally great and yet not equally punishable in different persons.

It is thus an individualization of morality that Holberg demands. In ethical evaluations and demands, account is to be taken of the inner personal conditions of individuals, and all cannot be cut by one measure. Holberg does not, it is true, go deeply into the problem that here comes to light, namely how far regard for the individual dispositions of particular persons can be reconciled with the demands that the existence of society makes. But the problem of the individual here steps forth for the first time in Danish thought. — On closer examination it will prove to be bound up with the question of the demonstrability and practicability of ethical principles.<sup>6</sup>

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Holberg not only felt an urge to think about ethical questions. He is at the same time the first here at home to have brooded over the influence that the new conception of

<sup>5</sup>See on this my *Etik* [Ethics] XI, 9 (cf. IV, 2). (Third edition, p. 221 f.; p. 89).

<sup>6</sup>Compare my essay on the Law of Relation in Ethics (*Etiske Undersøgelser* [Ethical Investigations], 1891, pp. 42–83).

the world — founded by Copernicus, Galileo, Descartes, and Newton — was bound to have on one's very view of life. He emphasizes here the enlargement that the picture of the world has received through the new discoveries and ways of seeing. The new astronomy has widened our conceptions and given us a greater idea of God. More than ever, speculations about God now stand as unreasonable. He declares himself in agreement with the Greek Simonides that the more one thinks about such questions, the more difficult they become. It is of no use to say, with "common theology," that Simonides speaks out of heathen blindness, but that revelation has brought enlightenment; for the figurative expressions that the Bible predominantly uses give no proper concept, indeed lead to "coarse and carnal conceptions." Holberg finds that those versed in nature have higher thoughts of the divine Being than the common crowd, indeed than many of the clergy themselves, in that they do not, like the latter, make attempts to express the incomprehensible. The deeper we enter into the investigation of what eternity, infinity, omniscience, omnipresence ("all-being"), and omnipotence are, the more we drown in them and see ever less.

According to the new picture of the world, moreover, the Earth stands as a grain of sand over against the infinite universe; it is no longer the centre of the world, and even the sun about which it revolves is only one star among countless other stars. Men are like worms that creep about on a little hillock and yet imagine that everything exists for their sake. From this side too it appears how hopeless metaphysical and theological speculations are.

In the world of natural science and of philosophy there still stood, in Holberg's time, the dispute between Descartes's and Newton's teachings concerning the motions of the heavenly bodies and the laws underlying them. Descartes assumed that the universe consisted of systems, each of which was in whirling motion. The globes belonging to the same vortex were driven round by the motion of the surrounding mass. That the globes did not, by virtue of the law of inertia, fly off into the universe away from the centre of their system was explained by the fact that the surrounding mass, in which they as it were swam, continually carried them round the centre. Newton rejected this vortex theory and explained the globes' remaining in their orbits by gravity or attraction, which constantly counteracted the tendency to fly off in a straight line. Holberg seems to have been much taken up with this discussion. "According to the cursory knowledge he has of it," he prefers to hold to the Cartesian conception, because it appears to him simple and intuitible, whereas Newton appears to him to appeal to a mysterious force when he speaks of attraction.

But if the universe consists of many worlds in constant whirling motion, how does this square with the biblical account of the creation of the world? This point had in Holberg's younger days caused him much doubt and unease. He settled the matter for himself, however, in this way: that the Mosaic creation-story tells only of the coming-into-being of the vortex-system to which the Earth belongs. There is, after all, nothing said about its having been the first or the only world that was created! Perhaps there takes place a perpetual arising and passing-away of worlds!

It is the boldest thought Holberg hints at. And with this thought there is given a great background for Holberg's view of the world, which his own caution and the pettiness of the age prevented him from bringing forth more definitely, but which is nonetheless felt in the freedom of spirit that his thought on the whole bears witness to. His conceptions of the decisive questions unfolded under the influence of a wide horizon, which would have come forth more clearly had he not himself, too much in the less happy sense of the words, "feared God and followed the highway."

Yet one point still remains as that in which Holberg deviated in the most decisive way from the orthodox way of thinking — namely his position on the problem of evil, a problem that shortly before his appearance had been discussed by Bayle and Leibniz. Pierre Bayle had maintained the impossibility of explaining the origin of evil if one started from the conception of an all-good and almighty God as the author of all things — and had declared that the only consistent assumption, when one took one's stand on the standpoint of natural reason with revelation left aside, was the presupposition of two original principles, a good and an evil, in constant strife and struggle, as the Manichaeans had taught. Holberg, however, could as little accept this dualistic conception as he could follow Leibniz in his optimistic speculations. But one of his friends, whom he designates by B. S. (it is supposed to be Rector Bernhard Schnabel in Roskilde), had shown him a way out: if God from the beginning stands over against a chaotic matter that is not perfectly receptive to the forms he wishes to impress upon it, but offers a certain resistance, then it is understood that not only the perfect exists, but also the imperfect. One then avoids the Manichaean assumption of two active principles, a good and an evil God, and holds fast to the belief in a good God whose carrying-out of his intentions is hampered by a recalcitrant matter. Such a view (of a kind similar to that in which Rousseau and Voltaire, and later Stuart Mill and William James, ended up) would — Holberg thinks — have disarmed Bayle, had revelation not taught a creation out of nothing. On this point his accommodation and apparent submission to Church doctrine is quite plain. With his teaching about the origin of our world-system as the successor of an earlier one, the

solution of the problem of evil here indicated would have fitted excellently.

For the rest, Holberg has yet another argument against Bayle. The different beings must be measured by different measures. A human being's perfection is other than a fly's and than an angel's; every being is perfect in its kind. This line of thought accords well with Holberg's individualizing of ethics, and it presupposes that the measure is taken from the very nature of the individual beings, each for itself. It raises a problem similar to the individualization of ethics, and in sharper form.

Here, as at several other points, Holberg has developed his thoughts neither fully nor consistently. But he has done a foundational work and made free movement of thought possible here at home. For the first time, great problems were discussed in his writings in Danish and in a Danish spirit.

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## 2. Sneedorff and the Wolffians

Holberg's figure fills so much of Danish intellectual life in the eighteenth century that there seems to be an empty space after him. In independent thinking, no one at the close of the century came near him. But he had awakened a desire to think and had shown the possibility of using the Danish language for it. Among the best of the younger men there stirred a sense of shame that there did not yet exist a Danish scientific literature, while other European peoples had long since begun to use their mother tongue in science.

The one who, as a thinker, worked most nearly in Holberg's spirit was Jens Schielderup Sneedorff. Like Holberg he was influenced by English and French literature. Shaftesbury and Montesquieu in particular exerted an influence on him. He was born in 1724 and studied at Göttingen, whose university was visited by many foreigners and where philosophy, political science, and natural science flourished. Later he served (1751–1761) as professor of law and political science at the newly founded Academy at Sorø, which in its brief flowering became the cradle of Danish scientific literature. He died as early as 1764.

Sneedorff praises Holberg's great services to our language and our literature. "But we should not be worthy of having such a fellow citizen if, out of laziness or baseness, we were to believe that there was nothing for us to do." The struggle for the mother tongue and for true, natural thinking goes hand in hand in Sneedorff. Away with barbarous technical terms and academic sword-play — with dead memory and dead abstraction!

According to the historians of language, the foundation of the more modern Danish language was laid by Sneedorff and his contemporaries. —

Sneedorff's thought concerns partly matters of law and the state, partly general philosophical points of view.

In the first respect the chief work is *Den borgerlige Regering* [Civil Government] (1757). The weight is here laid on the principle that a good government must follow principles that build on experience and accord with the nature of the people; only such a government can win the people's trust. Written laws, not least constitutions, are unnecessary — indeed they may be harmful on account of their unalterability, which

hinders the constant interplay with experience. The Danish absolute monarchy was in Sneedorff's eyes the only absolute monarchy that was grounded on the people's trust, and he protests therefore against its being called despotism. — But in order that experiences may be made, and that the nature of the people may reveal itself, public opinion must unfold freely, and to this again belong enlightenment as well as freedom in all civil relations for all estates, not least for the hitherto so neglected peasantry. Freedom makes men active and reasonable, and without freedom there is no honour! —

Absolute monarchy is here recognized because it is enlightened and popular, no longer because it is by the grace of God. A turn in thought and in justification that was bound to have far-reaching consequences!

Sneedorff was one of those who, in the domain of general ideas, worked to prepare the great agrarian reforms in Denmark at the close of the eighteenth century. Whereas Holberg had still held that the peasant must be kept to work by compulsory laws, Sneedorff and those of like mind maintained that both regard for personal freedom and for the common good — considerations that at bottom coincide — demanded changes in the peasants' condition.<sup>7</sup>

Sneedorff's general philosophical standpoint already reveals itself in his doctrine of law and the state, but he develops it more closely, partly in polemical forms, in his periodical *Den patriotiske Tilskuer* [The Patriotic Spectator] (especially in the first volume, 1761).

Where it is a matter of experience and the description of experience, or where it is a matter of finding expression for the life of feeling, there, according to Sneedorff, one cannot apply strict definitions and methods of proof. What essentially matters is to procure as full a content as possible, and a logical or mathematical formulation would here only have a narrowing effect — indeed, at bottom, rest on an illusion. On the ground of experience we reach only probabilities ("likelihoods"), not necessities. And we must be cautious about finding contradictions, for these may fall away with widened experience, which can teach us that there are far more possibilities than we imagined.

It is characteristic that Sneedorff, in his discussion of the relation of experience to logical contradictions, emphasizes the opposite side from the one on which Holberg dwelt. Holberg laid weight on the point that the greater the experience we gain, the more contradictions and difficulties we shall find. It was his business to find and pose

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<sup>7</sup>Compare E. Holm: *Om det Syn paa Kongemagt, Folk og borgerlig Frihed, der udviklede sig i den dansk-norske Stat i Midten af det attende Aarhundrede* [On the View of Royal Power, People, and Civil Liberty that Developed in the Dano-Norwegian State in the Middle of the Eighteenth Century] (University Programme, 1883), pp. 107–114.

problems. Sneedorff dwells especially on the working of widened experience to make the provisionally found contradictions fall away. This is bound up with the brighter tone that lies over his philosophizing, and with his hope in progress, but also with a weakening in the sense for the sharpness of problems — of the ever-recurring problems.

But Sneedorff is not dogmatic. Just as he has a clear eye for the hypothetical character of the propositions we draw from experience — the chief source of our knowledge — so too he has an eye for the role that analogy plays in the border-region of thought, indeed already when we wish to infer what goes on in the inner life of other beings. And he maintains that only individual things are real, while species and generic designations are due to our thinking. There is expressed in this last proposition a sense for the individual, which we have already met with in Holberg and shall find again in later Danish thinkers (Treschow, A. S. Ørsted, Kierkegaard). Sneedorff protests against philosophy's being metaphysics and logic alone. The study of the mind's operations and movements demands fineness and loftiness of thought no less than pure metaphysics, and jurisprudence and aesthetics now claim their right, after theology, philology, mathematics, and metaphysics have so long had the say.

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Holberg and Sneedorff belong to the kind of thinkers who strive to build on experience, with full awareness that by this path no absolute conclusion can be reached. They take a stand against the thinking that starts from certain dogmatically established principles, from which one then proceeds by strict inferences. Experience here receives a subordinate significance. For a large part, Sneedorff's expositions are directed against Jens Kraft (1720–1765), professor of mathematics at Sorø and author of a whole series of philosophical textbooks. Kraft had, in his *Kritiske Breve til Videnskabernes Fremvæxt og Smagens Forbedring* [Critical Letters on the Growth of the Sciences and the Improvement of Taste] (1761), defended the mathematical (deductive) method in science. He emphasized the indispensability of abstract thinking and of mathematics if knowledge is to be thorough and if it is to be applied in practice, and he fears that the preponderance of “the fine sciences” will lead to indolence and superficial cleverness. On Sneedorff's emphasizing of the method of experience, however, he does not enter.

Some years before (1751–1753), Kraft had published a systematic presentation of metaphysics after the method of the German philosopher Wolff. By metaphysics he understands “the doctrine of the first and most necessary fundamental teachings needed for human knowledge.” The first part is ontology, the doctrine of the most universal truths, which can be reduced to two: that the self-contradictory is impossible, and that

everything has its cause. The second part is cosmology, the doctrine “of the forces and primary physical properties of natural things,” the key to physics. Here he parts from Wolff by adopting Newton’s hypothesis and rejecting Descartes’s; the book thereby marks a turning point in Danish science. The third part is psychology. Here Wolff distinguished between rational (speculative) and experimental (empirical) psychology. Kraft fuses the two together, remarking: “Among all the theoretical discoveries about the soul I have found but few of importance, and I have therefore held that one might with propriety and right introduce them together with the experimental in a single work.” Here, then, Kraft himself wished to let experience come into its own. The fourth and last part is “the natural doctrine of God, or natural theology.” Here God’s existence is proved partly by the argument that there must be a first beginning to the changes in the world, since otherwise these would not have their sufficient ground, and the question of the origin would otherwise ever recur without being answered; partly by the argument that it lies in the concept of God as the infinite and perfect Being that he must exist, since he has his ground in himself and is not dependent on anything else that could exclude his existence.

Kraft’s work is the only completed system written in Danish. Apart from the individual points singled out, it rests entirely on Wolff’s philosophy, the first German system. Chr. Wolff was a disciple of Leibniz, and his philosophy is at once a popularization and a systematization of the master’s thoughts. He supplanted the old scholasticism at the German universities, just as Descartes had supplanted it in France and Holland, and Locke in England. But his theological colleagues at Halle feared the consequences of the new philosophy, partly because it so zealously maintained “the principle of sufficient reason,” which seemed to them to lead to fatalism, partly because it taught the possibility of a purely human morality. In Denmark too it was ill regarded while Pietism held sway. One of the first Danes to be influenced by it, Henrik Stampe, is said for that reason to have lodged “half incognito, at least as regards court chaplain Bluhme,” in Wolff’s house. Wolffianism was first introduced at the University of Copenhagen by jurists (Stampe, Kofod Anker) and theologians (Gunnerus). But the first purely philosophical writer here at home of this tendency was Frederik Christian Eilschow (1725–1750).

Just as Wolff in Germany created a philosophical terminology to replace the Latin one, and for the most part did so, so too it was one of Eilschow’s endeavours to replace the many foreign scientific words with Danish ones, and these had then first to be coined. Eilschow has often been felicitous in his proposals in this respect. Words such as *Enkelthed* (singularity), *Sandsynlighed* (probability), *Sædelighed* (morality), *Personlighed*

(personality), *Selvbevidsthed* (self-consciousness), *Sindsbevægelse* (emotion), and *Overflade* (surface) are due to him. He maintains that the sciences ought to be presented in the people's own language. Against those who held that there was no reason to abandon Latin, since practical people had no time for reading of a scientific kind anyway, he appeals to his own experience. There are many who, without belonging to the learned, buy and read scientific books whose language they understand; many hours, indeed whole nights, they spend absorbed in them.<sup>8</sup>

Eilschow praises the English because they lay such great weight on experience, and on account of the many profound thoughts that come from England. But he attaches himself predominantly to Wolff, whose philosophy he wishes to make more accessible, also to ladies,<sup>9</sup> and whose work he also wishes to continue.<sup>10</sup> Wolff had, indeed, set metaphysics in system, dividing it into fundamental doctrine (ontology), the doctrine of the world (cosmology), the doctrine of the soul (psychology), and natural theology. Eilschow did not himself treat all these subjects; such a treatment was, as already mentioned, given by Kraft some years later. It is natural theology that Eilschow especially occupies himself with. It is from the concept of possibility that Eilschow will conduct his proof of God's existence. No finite thing's possibility has its ground in itself; but all possibilities have their ultimate ground in God's possibility — and this has its ground in itself, just as all numbers presuppose the number one. This is, however, not to be understood as though the possibilities of things were due to God's will. They stand independently of his will in his eternal thought; only their realization is due to the will. Against the eternal possibilities the will can do nothing — the divine will as little as the human.

Now the source of evil — of pain and of sin — lies in the limitation to which everything finite as such is subject, and which follows from the fact that finite beings stand in connection with one another. This connection, which in itself is a good, brings with it barriers and therewith the possibility of imperfection. Evil cannot then be charged to God's account, since he has as little created the possibilities as he has created his own understanding.<sup>11</sup>

As little as Leibniz and Wolff has Eilschow answered the objection that Bayle raised and that Holberg repeated: why, then, has God created a world of which he knew that it contained the possibility of pain and sin, a possibility that neither divine nor human

<sup>8</sup>Eilschow: *Cogitationes de scientiis vernacula lingua docendis*, Hafniæ 1747, p. 7.

<sup>9</sup>*Forsøg til en Fruentimmerphilosophie* [Attempt at a Philosophy for Ladies]. Copenhagen 1749.

<sup>10</sup>*Philosophiske Breve over adskillige nyttige og vigtige Ting* [Philosophical Letters on Various Useful and Important Things]. Copenhagen 1748.

<sup>11</sup>*Philosophiske Breve*, p. 150. — A similar line of thought is found in Jens Kraft's *Naturlige Theologie*, pp. 13–16. — Eilschow states, however, that we cannot infer from the imperfections found in one part of the world to the imperfection of the whole.

will could annul? Holberg is more consistent than Eilschow. Understanding and will, possibility and actuality, are here in such a degree at war with one another that they must really belong to two different beings. The God who is willing but not able is not almighty; he has a barrier — whether one now, with Holberg, seeks it in an eternal matter, or, with the Manichaeans, in an eternal evil being, an Ahriman. — Eilschow lacks Holberg's sense for the seriousness of problems.<sup>12</sup>

On the question of the relation between reason and revelation, Eilschow likewise makes use of the distinction between possibility and actuality. God can reveal something that one cannot derive from reason and from the possibilities it establishes; but he cannot reveal anything that overthrows natural knowledge, contradicts the clearest reports of the senses, and upsets all that on which the certainty of all truths rests.

Just as Sneedorff recognized absolute monarchy because it worked in the service of enlightenment and of the popular cause, and not because it sprang from the grace of God, so Eilschow and the other Wolffians recognized revelation in the confidence that it does not contradict reason and the eternal possibilities. The question was bound to become — and did become — on which side the wrong lies when a contradiction actually shows itself. There came the time, toward the close of the century, when men were in no doubt that a contradiction was present, nor in doubt on which side the wrong lay.

For the time being, Eilschow was sure that he had in hand the means to refute the freethinkers, that is, those who deny the divine providence.<sup>13</sup> They sin against metaphysics and are refuted by means of the aforementioned doctrine of the possibilities and their ultimate ground. Without metaphysics one easily goes astray, precisely in such questions as the origin of evil and providence. Yet Eilschow thinks that the freethinkers really merely wish for freedom to sin, and that they deny the truth in order to escape obeying it. There are, to be sure, some — such as Spinoza — who have led a fine life; but that is inconsistent, since they expect no reward or punishment after death. —

More kindly disposed than toward the freethinkers is Eilschow toward the animals. He is one of the first philosophers of the modern age to maintain that we have duties toward animals. In order for one to have a duty toward a being, it is not necessary that it have reason, provided only that it has the capacity to suffer. There exists a community between them and us, in that we take their service and in return have duties toward them. —

<sup>12</sup>A purely philosophical standpoint on the problem of evil is given in my *Religionsfilosofi* [Philosophy of Religion], §§ 88–89, and my *Etik* [Ethics], chap. VI.

<sup>13</sup>The word freethinker comes from England (free-thinker) and first occurs around the year 1700, used of and by men such as Toland and Collins. Earlier, from the sixteenth century on, designations such as deists and naturalists were used in France.

Wolff's systematic philosophy held sway at the university until into the new century. Its last representative was Børge Riisbrigh (born 1731, died 1809), who was professor of philosophy from 1767 to 1803. His teaching is praised for its formal clarity, but he was not very productive. The most considerable work from his hand is a treatise (from 1802–03) on Kant's philosophy, a work that does him honour and that will be discussed later on.

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### 3. Danish Kantians and Their Opponents

The Wolffian system was in Germany supplanted by one of the most profound works of thought that the history of philosophy knows — by Kant's critical philosophy. Kant had been aroused by Hume's critique of the causal principle, the principle on which all natural science and all speculative philosophy and theology built. At the same time Newton's mathematically developed natural science stood before him as the ideal of scientific knowledge. When he now asked how such science was possible despite Hume's demonstration that the causal principle was neither self-evident nor demonstrable, he found the solution in this: that there are certain forms with which the human mind, according to its nature, constantly works, and of which it must therefore make use when it is to establish what has objective validity — what is truth and reality. Thereby it became at once possible to acknowledge science in its independence and to see its limits; these must lie where the human mind's forms of intuition and thought no longer find any given material to be applied to. Science cannot therefore go further than the possibility of experience goes. When this possibility fails, a person can — and must — have a personal faith to support his holding fast to the command of conscience; but a speculative theology is impossible.

The law of conscience was, according to Kant, a pure law of reason: just as the human mind in its science strives to bring observations under the forms and laws of intuition and understanding — under the forms of space and time, of the concept of magnitude and the concept of cause — so it can convince itself of the morality of an action only when it can show that the action can be acknowledged on the basis of a universal law valid for all; the maxim I follow in my action must be such that everyone in my place could follow it.

As Kant, from developed science, seeks back to the innermost nature of thought itself at work, so on the ethical-religious domain he sought back to the self-legislation of conscience. From the principles he thus gained, he judged the speculative systems

and the theological dogmas. His great sense for the original forces led him further, on the aesthetic domain, to point to genius as the involuntarily welling source of art. In thought, in conscience, and in genius there expresses itself, for Kant, one and the same fundamental force in different forms. By this great idea Kant at once forms the conclusion of the eighteenth century's intellectual labour and points far beyond its horizon.

It was a young, promising scholar who especially aroused attention for Kant's philosophy in Denmark. In the spring of 1793 Christian Hornemann (born 1769) delivered lectures on Kant's critique of reason. They were cut short by the author's death the same year, and the great hopes that had been placed in him fell to the ground. With great enthusiasm he had taken Kant's principal ideas into himself, and a period of study with Reinhold at Jena had developed his philosophical interest. In his lectures (which are printed in his *Efterladte Skrifter* [Posthumous Writings], 1795) he gave a clear account of the relation of the critical philosophy to earlier conceptions and then began to go through Kant's principal work; but he got no further than the end of the doctrine of space and time. — Hornemann's main task seems to have been to show how the religious problem would present itself under the presupposition of the new conception.

The purely theoretical side of Kant's philosophy was but little brought forward here at home, and just as little the aesthetic. It was the moral- and religious-philosophical side that was especially attended to. The most considerable champion of Kant's ethics and doctrine of right was the man who later became Denmark's greatest jurist, Anders Sandøe Ørsted (born 1778); in 1798 he won the university's gold medal for a prize essay *Om Sammenhængen mellem Dyds- og Retslærens Princip* [On the Connection between the Principle of the Doctrine of Virtue and that of the Doctrine of Right], an excellent presentation for its time of Kant's ethics and philosophy of right, and an account of the discussions to which this gave rise among contemporaries, both abroad and here at home. In the standing dispute between the "Bible party" (the Palaeologists) and the "Reason party" (the Neologists) — the first represented by Bishop Balle, the second by Horrebow (editor of the periodical *Jesus og Fornuften* [Jesus and Reason]) — Ørsted took part with a longer essay (in *Philosophisk Repertorium*, 1797–1798), directed against Horrebow's popular half-philosophy. From a standpoint similar to Lessing's in *Erziehung des Menschengeschlechts* and Fichte's in *Kritik aller Offenbarung*, he points beyond the two contending parties. — Ørsted did not — as we shall see in a later connection — remain at the strictly Kantian standpoint he had taken in these essays. But admiration and gratitude toward his great teacher followed him all his life, and in his advanced old age he expressed it in a beautiful way.

It was, as Ørsted remarks in his autobiography,<sup>14</sup> not so much the young theologians as the young jurists who occupied themselves with philosophy. And in the questions that occupied the last decade of the eighteenth century, the vigorous and free spirit that characterizes Kant's and Fichte's ethical and legal-philosophical views could have worked extraordinarily fruitfully. But there did not arise here, as in Germany, a series of independent and energetic thinkers and reformers such as those to whom the great reforms in Prussia after 1806 were due. The "Königsberg idealism," to which, according to Gneist, Prussia's restoration was for so large a part due, set no lasting effects in the life of the people here at home, and was early superseded by the more passive and dreaming tendency of Romanticism. This came partly from external political circumstances; partly, too, no doubt, from the fact that twelve years before the close of the century we had carried through one of the greatest reforms our country's history knows — a reform in which, moreover, as touched on in its place, philosophical ideas had also played a part. Besides Ørsted, whose philosophical and juridical studies in youth belonged to the preparation for his long activity as judge and legislator, one must nevertheless name a Kantian whose writings, by their clarity and energy, stand far above most of what was produced here at home in the public discussion that overflowed all its banks in the last decade of the eighteenth century, before the strict press regulation of 1799 stopped the free discussion of public affairs. The clergyman Michael Gottlieb Birckner (born 1756, died 1798) maintained, in his work *Om Trykkefriheden og dens Love* [On Freedom of the Press and Its Laws] (1797), that even in an absolute monarchy complete freedom of the press may very well prevail. — It was the ideal of enlightened absolutism — free discussion of all thoughts, and yet absolute obedience in all actions — that was here carried through to its uttermost consequence. Kant himself had, moreover, in his remarkable little essay *Was ist Aufklärung?* (1784), stated that only an enlightened autocrat, not a free state, dared say: Reason as much as you will — but obey! But it was then also Kant's opinion that such an autocrat the world had had only in Friedrich II of Prussia. Birckner's Kantianism had led him to continue a line of thought in which Sneedorff and his generation had already moved. In other domains too Birckner appears as a pronounced Kantian. Even more strongly than Kant, and without the sense for

<sup>14</sup>*Af mit Livs og min Tids Historie* [From the History of My Life and My Times], I (1851), p. 22. — A rather remarkable and independent position toward Kant's ethics was taken by the then professor of moral philosophy Anders Gamborg, who, following Hutcheson and Adam Smith, maintained a morality independent of religion and springing from love of humanity. In his first work (*Forskel mellem Dyd og gode Handlinger* [The Difference between Virtue and Good Actions], 1783) he does not yet know Kant's writings. In a later work (*Jesu Moral* [The Morality of Jesus], 1799) he declares that he is neither a eudaemonist nor a Kantian; yet he is glad that in his insistence on the unconditional character of the duty of truthfulness he agrees with Kant, though their grounds differ.

the sublime that marks the master's presentation, he asserts the sole right of reason in the ethical life. All feeling — with the exception of the pure feeling of respect that the moral law inspires — was for him really self-love. Even love of fatherland and love of humanity he would therefore not acknowledge as the proper ethical motives; they cannot be required and commanded, but must develop involuntarily, and it is not the immediate respect for the right that makes itself known in them, but the individual's personal captivation.<sup>15</sup> —

Among the Danish Kantians, Baggesen must also be named. In him it was not the strict, rational side of Kant's philosophy that aroused interest, but precisely that character of sublimity which Kant's thoughts can present, especially when they move on the borderlines of experience. Kant satisfied for a time the young poet's rapturous searching, though he admitted that the purely theoretical enthusiasm was foreign to him. He philosophized, as he himself says in a letter to Reinhold,<sup>16</sup> out of ethical and religious interest, and his work of thought really always aimed at procuring symbols for what moved in his feeling and his imagination. Philosophy was for him "Gedankenspiel" [a play of thoughts]: "Since I do not work in philosophy and on philosophy, my philosophizing — whether it consist in the reading of philosophical works or in conversation with philosophical friends — is only play, but the dearest of all plays."<sup>17</sup> Poetry and philosophy strove over this strange spirit. And he stood not only on the border between two domains of the spirit, but also on the border between two centuries. We shall meet him later in the remarkable collision with Grundtvig, which promised so much but came to so little, because in Baggesen the play with symbols gained the upper hand over the seriousness of thought.

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<sup>15</sup>See his essays *Om Kierlighed til Fædrelandet* [On Love of the Fatherland] and *Om Christendommens højeste Moralprincip* [On the Highest Moral Principle of Christianity] (*Efterladte Skrifter* [Posthumous Writings], ed. A. S. Ørsted, Copenhagen 1800). — On the ethical and psychological misunderstandings in Kant's and Birckner's conception, see my *Etik* [Ethics] XII, 1.

<sup>16</sup>*Aus Jens Baggesens Briefwechsel mit Reinhold und Jacobi*, I, p. 6.

<sup>17</sup>*Op. cit.*, II, p. 56. — It is of interest to hear Reinhold's judgment of Baggesen, made to a third party: "Sein darstellender Genius ist sein Plagegeist. In den Augenblicken, wo er ihn in Ruhe lässt, ist Baggesen im Denken Philosoph und im Handeln verständiger Mann von der ersten Grösse — aber das sind auch nur Augenblicke — sonst ist er Engel oder Teufel, und befindet sich im Himmel oder in der Hölle — leider! öfters da als dort. Als Korrespondent (wenn er schreibt) und als auf einige Tage besuchender Gast hat er wohl Niemanden über sich." [His representative genius is his tormenting spirit. In the moments when it leaves him in peace, Baggesen is in thought a philosopher and in action a sensible man of the first rank — but those too are only moments — otherwise he is angel or devil, and finds himself in heaven or in hell — alas, more often there than here. As a correspondent (when he writes) and as a guest visiting for a few days he has, I think, no one above him.] Reinhold to Erhard, 2 Aug. 1796. (*Denkwürdigkeiten des Philosophen und Arztes Erhard*, ed. Varnhagen von Ense, 1830, p. 426).

Kantianism was met with no small resistance here at home from various sides, not least from the side of self-satisfied “Enlightenment.” And literary spokesmen such as Rahbek were vexed at the young Kantians’ arrogance and the new technical terms they threw about. “Enlightenment” was, moreover, agreed with Orthodoxy that it could not be so difficult as Kant thought to get the riddles of existence solved. Why all the many preparations, when one had one’s Bible and one’s catechism or one’s “sound common sense” to resort to?

But the new tendency of thought also found really philosophical opponents, and some of these have even with clarity pointed out defects and unsolved questions in the critical philosophy. Tyge Rothe and Johannes Boye collided with criticism in the course of their work at developing their own ideas, while Riisbrigh, Niels Schow, and Treschow directly examined its foundation and range.

Tyge Rothe’s (born 1731, died 1795) authorship falls into two periods, a historical-political and a philosophical. To the first period belong his writings on the influence of Christianity on the condition of the peoples in Europe and on the history of the North, which gave him occasion to work for the emancipation of the peasantry. To the second period belongs his chief philosophical work *Philosophies Ideer til Kundskab om vor Art og til Glæde over den* [Philosophy’s Ideas toward Knowledge of Our Kind and Joy in It] (1788–1789). It is here not, as has been said and repeated, one of the ordinary spokesmen for Enlightenment and the doctrine of felicity who has the word. Rothe is influenced by men such as Herder and Jacobi. He was thinking of laying down his pen when Herder’s *Ideen* appeared, but yet took courage to walk in his footsteps. He is clear that neither man’s nobility nor his happiness can be judged merely by his enlightenment. Free humanity, working its way toward inner harmony and toward sympathy with all that is human, is for him man’s vocation. Social life develops out of the free and undisturbed urge of hearts, not out of need and misery, nor out of pure reason. And like his two German masters he finds in immediate feeling an organ for the highest: by a revelation of nature, not through handed-down articles of faith or by the way of pure reason, we discover our own being as caused by an eternal being, and therewith the causal law itself is given in its inevitability. All philosophy is therefore theology. The doctrines of positive religion are interpreted according to the doctrines of nature’s revelation, which experience too confirms; Newton’s demonstration of the lawfulness of nature leads back to nature’s springing from the will of a single being; he has given us the physico-theology that so gloriously characterizes our enlightened age.

Kant’s teaching belongs (like Spinoza’s, Berkeley’s, and Hume’s) to “the dark philo-

sophical systems.” It shakes the empiricist philosophy on which alone we can build with security. — It is evidently partly Kant’s discussion of the causal principle as not immediately given or evident, partly his critique of the proofs of God’s existence, that repels Rothe. He is sure that when Kant has closely determined how far strict knowledge goes, then men will feel that they cannot be content with it, and will work their way out of the dark labyrinth into the clear daylight of immediate assurance.

Rothe represents a standpoint that otherwise does not come forth here at home at the close of the eighteenth century. He lacks Herder’s originality and Jacobi’s remarkable union of criticism and pathos, and his sentimentality and artificiality contrast strongly with their assertion of the right of the involuntary and the immediate in the life of the spirit. But it was not without significance that a tone of this kind too, weak and sometimes false though it was, came to sound among the many voices of the age here at home. —

Rothe had received influence not only from German writers, but also from French literature. It was especially the Genevan Charles Bonnet, the naturalist and philosopher,<sup>18</sup> who inspired him and was his guide in the contemplation of nature. He embraces Bonnet’s doctrine of preformation, according to which each species was created for itself and in such a way that the germs of all later individuals were contained in the first representatives of the species. All beings form one great chain, but the links in this chain of nature remain through the ages specifically (“according to kind”) distinct, and no transformation of the species or transition from one species to another takes place. The original dispositions in nature cannot be annulled by any mechanical force. Man is perfect in his first disposition, but external circumstances, great upheavals of the Earth, have intervened inhibitingly and altered the disposition, so that a long and laborious development became necessary. At every stage of development, however, it holds that a being attains the satisfaction it is possible for it to reach. Through this consideration the harmony of existence asserts itself for Rothe’s thought. He expressly rejects the way out that Eilschow and Kraft (following Leibniz and Wolff) had seized upon: to distinguish between the possibilities for the divine understanding and the actuality as it springs from the divine will. “Only one could God’s plan be; that plan was the only one that could be put into effect, for away with the foolish talk that God pondered and weighed

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<sup>18</sup>Bonnet was among the foreigners supported by the Danish government under Frederik V. His still instructive psychological work *Essai analytique sur les facultés de l’âme* (of particular interest for the psychology of attention and of the will) was printed in Copenhagen in 1760 and dedicated to Frederik V. Though a republican, he praised the Danes as fortunate in having such a monarch: “Ce republicain envieroit le sort de l’heureux Danois, si un citoyen de Genève pouvoit envier quelque chose!” [This republican would envy the lot of the happy Dane, if a citizen of Geneva could envy anything!]

and chose!” “What could be in God’s realm of creation, that is there. What could subsist, that subsists.” Why influences (or, as Tyge Rothe says, “impacts”) hinder the unfolding of the dispositions, of that, according to Rothe, one can give no explanation. For our sake the eternal laws are not altered; nor are they given for our sake. But this thought does not darken Rothe’s bright view of things. — Optimism is rising — from Holberg through Eilschow and Kraft to Tyge Rothe. —

Whereas Rothe conceives development as merely the unfolding of original germs, Johannes Boye (born 1756, died 1830) stands as a philosopher of development in the more modern sense of the word. In his remarkable work *Statens Ven* [The Friend of the State] (1792 ff.) he lays down the thought that everything endowed with force, man included, must struggle with resistance and violence to reach its goal. No one sleeps himself good, but every step forward toward perfection must be won by struggle. Only through strife and labour is man helped forward to what he is. A struggle of all against all is waged. Bravery was a virtue before piety became one, and physical superiority prevailed before spiritual superiority could be exercised. Nature brings up its children strictly — but thereby it brings up heroes. The lazy and the weak are pushed aside in that strife of forces through which order and harmony are won. This blessed strife is the means that Providence uses for the realization of the world-plan.

Right and morality depend on the development of culture, and it is the annals of history, not speculative vapouring, that can teach us something about their origin. Man has developed from an animal state and from brutality, through all degrees of culture, to the height he now occupies. And the state is the most important aid to culture. The life of the state is grounded on the understanding of the necessity of renouncing some of one’s rights in order to preserve the others. Through social life and by the aid of language man has ceased to be an animal; without them we should still be living among the animals in the forest and eating acorns with them. But development does not halt at a self-limitation in expectation of reciprocity. The fundamental urge in us is first satisfied in sympathy and noble self-feeling. Man then feels himself as part of a whole; his thought gazes out over wider circles, and his interest is extended far beyond his own self. At this standpoint virtue is its own reward. Even self-sacrifice becomes possible only through the urge to use the great force led by sympathy. —

From this standpoint Boye combats the critical philosophy’s attempt to build morality and right on pure reason. This philosophy halts, he says, at an unreconciled opposition between pure reason and the psychological motives. “A good will” must, after all, be a will that is good toward someone, and should love of humanity be reprehensible because

in it man follows a deep urge? The ideas of the good and the right develop out of human interests and their conflict. —

Boye's line of thought, here given in condensed form, does not come into its own in his books and is therefore easily misunderstood by superficial readers. It is a manly and free view that stirs in him, and it had not deserved the oblivion that has become its lot, but which is explained by the spirit of the age, which was first facilely optimistic and soon after rapturously Romantic. Yet Boye lacked sufficient historical sense and sufficient material to give his ideas a thorough foundation.

A. S. Ørsted, who in his prize essay answered Boye's attack on Kant's ethics, acknowledges his work as "spirited and tasteful." He agrees with Boye that the most probable hypothesis is that humanity in its childhood did not stand high above the animals — an assumption that Kant too had put forward (in his essay *Muthmaaslicher Anfang des Menschengeschlechts*, 1786). But he impresses the difference between the historical development of knowledge or of conscience and the philosophical demonstration of the presuppositions on which all knowledge and all conscience build — or between the beginning of knowledge and its foundation. — Ørsted is right that Kant's opponents constantly overlooked (and in part still overlook) this difference; but Kant has undeniably himself contributed much to the misunderstanding, especially by not giving the psychological and historical inquiry its due. —

Børge Riisbrigh found in his advanced old age the time and the inclination to discuss the philosophy that supplanted the doctrine he had proclaimed throughout his long university activity. And he does it with an acuteness and an impartiality that do him honour. His inquiry appeared in the Transactions of the Society of Sciences in 1803,<sup>19</sup> the same year in which he withdrew from his teaching activity, and it is still of interest. He shows first that already before Kant men had been aware that what our knowledge presupposes and applies in its investigation of objects cannot, at the very moment of application, have come from the objects themselves, but must have been in the mind beforehand, whether in its first origin it stems from experience or not. There is, then, a "pre-experiential knowledge" (knowledge *a priori*). But Kant first sought the source of these principles in the human mind itself and showed their purely formal character,

<sup>19</sup>Its title is: "Undersøgelse om og hvorvidt deres Mening er grundet, som holde for, at sand Filosofi og et fuldstændigt Begreb om sand Filosofi først i vore Tider ere blevne til" [Inquiry whether, and how far, the opinion is well founded of those who hold that true philosophy and a complete concept of true philosophy have first arisen in our times]. — Philosophy was not among the subjects represented in the Danish Royal Society of Sciences from its founding (1742). Only under A. P. Bernstorff's presidency were (1795) "the properly philosophical sciences, or the so-called speculative philosophy, which in recent times has acquired so much importance," added to the mathematical, physical, and historical subjects. C. Molbech: *Det kongelige danske Videnskabernes Selskabs Historie i dets første Aarhundrede*, p. 283.



and gave a catalogue of them. He thereby laid the foundation of a new science within philosophy, the scientific critique of reason. But he did not, like some of his successors, assert that before him men had neither true philosophy nor knew what philosophy was. And he by no means spurned experience; he assumed both an experiential and a pre-experiential philosophy.

Riisbrigh wishes, as a counterpart to Kant's inquiry into pure reason, an inquiry into empirical reason, and he thinks that one would then come to see its great significance. One would then again appreciate what Socrates, Aristotle, Bacon, and Locke had taught. On behalf of science, indeed of all human culture, one must warn against undervaluing the science of experience. Our inquiry must, after all, occupy itself with objects other than its own forms. And on the other hand these forms are themselves something given: the mind has as little given itself its essential forms as it has produced the forms in the world of sense! —

In the same volume of the Transactions of the Society of Sciences that brought Riisbrigh's essay, there is an essay by the philologist and archaeologist Niels Schow (born 1754, died 1830) that likewise presents no small interest.<sup>20</sup> The author finds Kant's significance especially in the movement in thought that he had aroused; whereas he finds the critique that G. E. Schulze had directed at Kant's philosophy (especially in *Kritik der theoretischen Philosophie*, 1801) altogether decisive. It is especially the critique of Kant's strange concept "Ding an sich" [thing in itself] that is at issue. Schow maintains that whether the absolute reality whose existence we know is contained in the subject or in the object, or in what relation it stands to both, we do not know; we only trace its effects. It exceeds the limit of human reason to give a positive determination. Even the most sublime philosophical presentations — like Spinoza's — are here anthropomorphisms. The task of philosophy is to determine the limits to which our knowing is ever subject — to discuss the results of the science of experience in their significance for the ultimate questions — and to work toward a harmony between acting and knowing. Beyond the hypothetical we do not come.

Already several years before Riisbrigh's and Schow's essays appeared, Niels Treschow (born 1751, died 1833), in Kristiania, where he was then headmaster, had delivered lectures on Kant's philosophy<sup>21</sup> and given a critical assessment of it that went deeper than any of

<sup>20</sup>Its title is: "Den nuherskende Skepticisme eller Kritik i Filosofien kan, naar den grunder sig paa den menneskelige Fornuft og rigtigt anvendes, ej være farlig, hverken for videnskabelig Cultur eller Moralitet" [The now-prevailing skepticism or criticism in philosophy cannot, when it is grounded on human reason and rightly applied, be dangerous, either to scientific culture or to morality].

<sup>21</sup>*Forelæsninger over den Kant'ske Philosophie* [Lectures on the Kantian Philosophy]. Copenhagen 1798.

the hitherto mentioned works on this subject. In a clear and lively presentation Treschow gives a survey of Kant's philosophy and attaches to it his critical remarks. He finds the derivation of the pure forms of the understanding unsatisfactory in Kant, and shows in particular that Kant could not rightly appeal to the current logic's division of judgments when he himself alters this. And even if Kant had succeeded in finding all the forms that knowledge makes use of, it would still have to be shown what it is in the given, in the "material," that makes possible and occasions the application of a definite particular form in the individual particular case. What makes it, for example, that I see here a quadrangle, there a triangle? It cannot be derived from space as a general form of intuition. What makes it that I apply here the concept of magnitude, there the concept of cause? It cannot be derived from the understanding's general power to combine observations in certain forms (categories). There must in the things themselves lie something at the ground of the particular modes of combination. Already our sensations must teach us what nature itself has combined and what it has separated.

There is lacking, according to Treschow, in Kant's presentation of the forms of thought (the categories), such important concepts as likeness (identity) and difference, agreement and conflict, which are nevertheless applied in all thinking, and which are just as much applied to the given as the concepts of magnitude and of cause. And the said concepts are even of quite special significance: the understanding's work really consists merely in the comparison of what is given in experience. It is according to the likeness or unlikeness of things, their agreement or conflict, that the understanding decides which combinations among them have validity and which not. — Treschow has here pointed to an important point in the theory of knowledge. Kant had not seen that the formal logical principles, just as much as the mathematical principles and the causal principle, are applied to the given material, so that their validity too must be examined by the critique of reason.

It is the standpoint of empiricist philosophy that Treschow maintains against Kant. He praises the Britons, who here not only have themselves come nearest to the truth and made considerable progress in knowledge of human nature, but have also become teachers for others. He upholds John Locke's standpoint against Leibniz and Kant, and reproaches the Germans for not having been willing to learn from the English. Locke was right that every form presupposes a material, and that no concepts can be formed when certain representations are not given beforehand.

But Treschow misunderstands Kant when he says that, according to Kant, the understanding forms its concepts "before any experience comes to it." It is, indeed, as A.

S. Ørsted showed against Boye, Kant's express teaching that knowledge *begins with* experience, even if not all knowledge *grounds itself on* experience. Experience itself was, according to Kant, composed of given material (the sensations) and involuntarily applied forms (forms of intuition and categories).

With the limitation that Kant establishes for our knowledge, Treschow is likewise not satisfied, as little as with the way in which Kant will have that urge satisfied which science cannot satisfy. "Kant himself cannot deny that there lies in our nature an indescribable longing to know more than he holds it possible to attain — indeed, he confesses, what is still more, that the aim of our existence necessarily demands a knowledge that we are able to attain by none of the indicated ways [those of sense-observation and of understanding]. Does he then intend to bring us back under the yoke of blind faith and the hierarchy, or is it deliberately that he, as in a heroic poem, entangles the knot in order to drive attention to the highest and earn the greater admiration by loosing it?" — Treschow despairs of Kant's art and will not build on the new foundation that Kant wished to lay for one's view of life. It is questionable to give practical reason and faith the right to overstep the limits of knowledge. How can it be proved that certain articles of faith indicate the only way in which the ethical ideas can be maintained? And if one gives up all demonstration and appeals merely to personal interest, then one opens the door to disputes of faith and persecutions. About that which is only to have practical significance, everyone — and not least those in power — will think they have a voice. — Treschow's misgivings are not unfounded. Another question is whether Kant is not right that what is decisive for every view of life is in the end a personal urge arising from the experience of life. With this every faith, whether it supports itself on science or not, must be able to accord. The great thing in Kant is precisely the art with which he tightens the opposition between the power of thought and the urge of life. He only did not see that the urge of life cannot once for all be shown to have found its satisfaction in the dogmas of "natural religion," any more than in those of any other religion. —

Treschow, whom we have here met only as a critic, we shall later meet as a distinctive and independent thinker who in several directions exercised a considerable influence on Danish intellectual life.



## 4. Henrik Steffens

*[Translation pending.]*



## **5. Hans Christian Ørsted**

*[Translation pending.]*





## 6. Grundtvig and H. C. Ørsted

*[Translation pending.]*



## 7. Baggesen and Grundtvig

*[Translation pending.]*



## **8. Anders Sandøe Ørsted**

*[Translation pending.]*



## **9. F. G. Howitz**

*[Translation pending.]*





## 10. Niels Treschow

*[Translation pending.]*



## **11. Frederik Christian Sibbern**

*[Translation pending.]*



## 12. Poul Møller

*[Translation pending.]*



## 13. Heiberg and Martensen

*[Translation pending.]*





## 14. Søren Kierkegaard

*[Translation pending.]*



## 15. Frederik Dreier

*[Translation pending.]*



## 16. Rasmus Nielsen

*[Translation pending.]*



## **17. Hans Brøchner**

*[Translation pending.]*